



SHRIYA PATIL

The 30-floor

mansion on Altamont Road will have a 360-degree sea view. With a home theatre, a health club, a lap pool and a helipad, it is estimated to cost Rs 600 crore.



numbers are proof of the success of this strategy. Take the post-liberalisation phase and you see the Reliance turnover galloping from Rs 2,098 crore in 1991 to Rs 23,024 crore in 2001. As the Indian economy boarded the 8-plus per cent bandwagon, RIL's turnover changed orbits to touch the trillion-rupee mark in 2006, and moved 73 rungs in one year to be ranked 269 on the Fortune 500 list in 2007.

Success, though, has always been accompanied by controversy. Reliance believes in changing the rules of the game and in muscling the system when the rules don't suit them. This was most visible in telecom, where, by choosing a combination of a gap in regulation, technology and scale, Mukesh made distance irrelevant, delivering telephony at 40 paise per minute. "People didn't believe me when I said we would notch a million connections within the year. Today I can say that I believe that without RIL's entry, the mobile revolution on the low-cost path would not have happened."

In all his ventures, Mukesh has dealt with complexities and scale. Old friend and ICICI MD and CEO K.V. Kamath says, "The basic strategy is to dream big and make the dream a reality. That requires the ability to think laterally and work to execute excellence. Mukesh has it in him to do it repeatedly." Take the 27-million-tonne-per-annum refinery. A mind-boggling civil and engineering feat, the refinery will use enough concrete to build many towers like Canada's CN



HOME AND THE HEART: With his wife, daughter Isha and sons Anant (left) and Akash; the new home (top left)

Tower, will require laying of 5,200 km of pipes equal to the length of the Ganges, and involve instrumentation facilities with cables long enough to stretch across the diameter of the earth. But such is the confidence in him that the market cap of Reliance Petroleum has already breached the Rs 1,00,000-crore mark. His oil and gas exploration project is among the largest in the world. Reliance is prospecting for carbon resources across an area of 4,25,000 sq km, almost the size of Iraq. Drilling 4.8 km deep into the sea, it located gas reserves of 11.3 trillion cubic feet in the Krishna-Godavari basin. Evacuating this gas involves installing equipment 3 km deep to bring it 2 km onshore before it is transported 1,400 km to Gujarat on a four-foot wide east-west pipeline. Anand Mahindra, vice-chairman and managing director, Mahindra Group, says, "What is unique about Mukesh is his astonishing vision, which is aligned to his unshakable faith in the huge potential of India's economy."

The gas business has not just been an engineering marvel. For over 12 months, Mukesh fought a bitter public battle on gas pricing as his brother Anil Ambani petitioned the Government and went to the courts to get his share of gas. Working through the corridors of power, through an empowered group of ministers, Mukesh has got a price that